

The Leadership Field Kit

For managers who want other leaders to call them when they've got a mess.

Eventually running your own team well isn't enough. You want to help other managers, have a say in how things get done, and get pulled into bigger problems.

I hate the phrase "personal brand." This isn't that. Do good work, figure out what you actually believe, and make the useful parts easy for other people to steal.

Do enough useful stuff that people mention your name when you're not there.

1. What do you want to be known for?

"Leadership" isn't a thing to be known for. Neither is "strategic." Pick something real: fixing bad territories, building a partner motion, getting new managers productive, selling into federal health.

Pick one. You can add more later. It should be specific enough that somebody could say, "If you've got a problem with _____, call her."

If your boss had one sentence to describe you to another leader today, what would it be? If you don't like the sentence, that's the work.

2. Where are your receipts?

Nobody remembers your whole year. Keep receipts: date, what you changed, what happened.

At the next level, "my team hit 112%" is good. Better is something you built that other people started using, or a rep you developed who now runs a team.

3. What do you believe that's actually yours?

Most good managers have a point of view. A lot of them have never bothered to write it down.

Write down three things you believe about running a sales team now that you didn't five years ago. They don't need to sound profound. "Most forecast misses are path problems" works. "Communication matters" doesn't.

Pick the one you'd argue for in a room full of people who disagree. Write that one.

Worksheet: My point of view

Three things I believe now that I didn't five years ago

The one I'd defend in a room that disagrees

The evidence I'd bring

Who disagrees, and where they're partly right

4. Build something other managers can borrow

If you do something well, write down how you do it and give it away. Your forecast call. Your first thirty days with a new rep. A hiring scorecard. Whatever people keep asking you about.

It doesn't need to be pretty. It needs to be useful enough that another manager uses it next week.

Then teach it. Thirty minutes at a leadership meeting, lunch with two newer managers, a session at kickoff. Teaching also tells you pretty quickly whether you actually know it.

5. Get into the right rooms

Start close to the work: your boss, your boss's peers, and the leaders you depend on in partners, marketing, finance and customer success. Then go wider.

The rooms you want are the ones where somebody is making decisions about your world without you: territories, headcount, your team's story, customers, industry stuff.

Usually the way in is simple: help somebody who's already in the room. Bring the template, the analysis, or the answer they keep getting asked for.

6. Bring people up behind you

If your people keep getting promoted, people notice. It's hard to fake that one.

Know who on your team could run a team. Give them the harder work. Put them in front of your boss. If they get promoted, that goes on your record.

Worksheet: A year from now

I want people to call me when they need help with

Three things I know unusually well

One point of view I'm willing to defend

One thing I could teach other managers

One useful thing I could publish or share

Five peers I'd like to know better

One room I'm not in yet, but should be

Don't try to manufacture recognition. Do good work. Leave useful stuff behind. Eventually people start mentioning you before you walk in.

Sometimes you just need another set of eyes

If this gets you into one better room, good enough.

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